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2 Learning About the Past Through Digital Play: History Students and Video Games

Abstract: This chapter examines history students' perceptions of their learning about the past through playing video games. We present a speculative design fiction that draws on data from a survey of student gamers' perceptions of their learning about history through videogaming. We used responses to the survey to create a story that explores both what students thought that they had learnt about history through playing "historical" video games in their free time and how they thought that they had learnt it. In addition, we explore why our respondents engaged in historical gameplay and what playing such games encouraged them to do beyond the digital world. Our aim is to understand students' roles as active agents in learning about the past through virtual play rather than as passive consumers of digital products.

The storyworld of MD 348211 – Playing the Past: making history in digital spaces 01

Motivation

Gaming for me is about escapism and challenge. I love it when I can't get off a game. I love the realism, action, the potential for strategy, the interaction, the attention to detail in the gameplay and the graphics. And the freedom in the game to explore. It's a draw like no other media.

So, a module based on playing computer games? Of course, I would choose that. I love gaming. My favourite? *Assassins Creed* because it is thoroughly enjoyable, and is what sparked my interest in history as a child, and led to me pursuing it at uni. As well as this, the game is fun, entertaining, well designed, challenging and, at the same time, educational. It (the module) was an opportunity to do something different where I could try out role playing as historical characters, rather than writing about them. I was also interested to see what it would be like to design a historical game that my friends could play.

Experience

The module runs twice a semester for seven days in total each time. It's tricky to get a place on it because there is a cap of 40 students. And it's popular because students like the idea of getting credit for playing video games! But many of us are also interested in the variety of different ways you are able to get involved, from RPG (role play game) aspects to working together and even getting the chance to design a game for the next group of students. I really like the concept of alternative history and wanted to see what it was like to see historical events play out in different ways from different perspectives.

We were told at the start of the module that we'd have to adopt a variety of different roles over the week. Some of the others were a bit nervous about this because they prefer playing solo, but I love the teamwork aspect of gaming so I was looking forward to it.

We all started the module in the first-person role and, although it was fun, at first, I couldn't really see what we were learning by rampaging around the medieval countryside. But as it went on, the prompts during gameplay, interactions with other characters, and the beauty of the architecture really drew me in and I learnt a lot about everyday life in medieval Italy as well as developing my combat skills. Every hour or so, we had to take a break and record a quick voice memo about what we had learned. At the end of the day, we had read a blog post about late medieval Italy that our tutor sent to us and had to write a paragraph or two in our online learning diaries.

I felt like I had a better idea of what was going on the next day when I joined three other students to complete a quest from Florence to Rome. It was good to work together and fun to be travelling around Italy and learning about all the different cities, although some of the others weren't taking it that seriously all the time. Then I got really into it and we played through the night on a side quest (not a module requirement). The learning center has 24-hour access and so we can still use the VR rooms to continue our game.

Then I slept . . .

On the fourth day I had the choice of doing the strategy game either on my own or in a group. I decided to pair up with one of my friends and we were given the position of a general in charge of the army of Milan planning a campaign against Florence. We're used to gaming together, so I think that we made a good team and we didn't have too many disagreements! The fact that if we made a mistake, we could go back and try again meant that we could think about alternative histories.

On the fifth and sixth days, I was part of a team that designed elements of the game for the next time the module runs. Some of my teammates are really into modding games to make them more interesting or accurate, so they really got into this task. We were given a pre-formatted "world" so we only had to add the details that we had researched about medieval life.

I prefer gameplay and experiencing different historical worlds so this was a bit less interesting to me. But I did learn a lot about how to use digital mapping software so that the game could be played in historical spaces, and about how important stories and characters are to game design.

Learning

Once we completed the week-long gameplay (equivalent to 40 hours of study) we then had a week to document and reflect on our experiences before the assessment submission.

I loved the module. Some of my friends said that it wasn't "proper" History, and I sort of understand that, but it was great to be able to bring my passion for gaming together with my love of History.

But playing this way meant that we explored different elements of living in a quasi-medieval world. We could do things that would not have been feasible in real life, let alone in other modules. Working through key decisions to be made with other students offered me insights into the complex nature of history. We were able to shape our own history through making choices based on real-life past events – it was so difficult! And we got assessed on how we engaged and reflected on these experiences.

I love that the university has offered this immersive experience. The world that the "game developer students" have created is filled with a rich back story and impressive environment

(luckily, we have an agreement/relationship with a local games developer who donated the game engine so we had a prototype into which we could insert specific elements of the game, including historical information that we had researched).

Even though I wasn't as into the game design aspect of the module as some of the others, I feel like I learned a lot by getting to play with the past, rather than just observing it from a distance. It's not for everyone, but I think it could help some students understand how history "works" (rather than just about what happened in the past) by doing modules like this. When I looked back at my learning journal, I noticed that I enjoyed – or at least learnt something from – working through the "grind" of gameplay with other students. It also made me much more interested in Renaissance Italy than I'd ever have thought possible!

This speculative fiction draws on responses to a survey of how students' experiences of video gaming affected their understanding of and engagement with history. Over 200 students responded to our survey, from which we identified key themes and emblematic quotations to inform the above fiction, a student's account of their experience on the module *MD 348211 – Playing the Past: making history in digital spaces 01*. Our intention was to use this fiction to kick-start a discussion about how experiences of historical gaming might inform teaching and learning practice. In the next section, we present the results of our analysis of the survey by relating them to the three elements which structured our fiction: motivation, experience, and learning. Each of these elements is connected to our larger survey and relevant literature on video games and history.

Motivation

Students choose modules for a variety of reasons, broadly divided between intrinsic motivations, extrinsic motivations, and module characteristics.¹ Respondents to our survey were self-selecting and, as such, were unsurprisingly positive about the experience of playing video games in general and historical video games in particular. One said "History is made interactive, never before would I have taken such an interest in the Third Crusade or Italian Renaissance." Positivity about gaming suggested that there would be an intrinsic openness to taking a module that involved playing and making historical video games. This was expressed by some respondents through reference to the interest of the subject matter: "The game further drove my interest in medieval

¹ M. R. Hedges, G. A. Pacheco, and D. J. Webber, "What determines students' choices of elective modules?," *International Review of Economics Education* 17 (2014): 39–54.

conflict and on a very simplified level the idea of medieval wartime politics, and the difficulties of maintaining the identity of a nation during times of conflict.”

Video games are often marketed and experienced as opportunities for players to exercise agency through their ludic structures and processes. Although this view has been critiqued on the grounds that what is cultivated is actually an illusion of gamer agency and subjectivity,² the key point is that historical games create a sense of agency on the part of those that play them. Respondents to our survey certainly felt this way: “The plot arc gives a real sense of empowerment . . . The tactical edge format means that I feel like I’m being engaged mentally, too.” This reflects a certain level of self-awareness about the constructed and subjective nature of the gaming experience.

Research has suggested that gamers’ sense of agency depends on a broad range of ludic, social, and psychological factors. Player immersion in game worlds does not, as is often assumed by designers and players, necessarily depend on the fidelity of graphics and sound within the virtual environment (i.e. “accuracy”).³ Indeed, Copplestone has suggested that players who are familiar with the media find that it offers a platform to “challenge how concepts of accuracy were formed and applied.”⁴ Rather, across different game types, a major predictor of player engagement and immersion is “the degree to which games satisfy motivational needs. Video game play that satisfies the needs for competence, autonomy, and relatedness increases a player’s sense of immersion” considerably.⁵ There is also an association between the authenticity of the virtual environment and player motivation, including their relationship to real world cognition and behavior. Importantly, playing video games can lead to a sense of fulfilment on the part of the gamer – the very act of gaming is thus potentially a motivating factor in and of itself.⁶

Studies of historical games have also suggested that they enable gamers to exercise a certain kind of agency. Uricchio, for instance, argued that historical

2 A. Charles, “Playing with one’s self: notions of subjectivity and agency in digital games,” *Eludamos. Journal for Computer Game Culture* 3, no. 2 (2009): 281–94.

3 E. Stirling, and J. Wood, “‘Actual history doesn’t take place’: Digital Gaming, Accuracy and Authenticity,” *Games Studies* 21, no. 1 (2021), accessed February 2, 2022, http://gamestudies.org/2101/articles/stirling_wood.

4 T. J. Copplestone, “But that’s not accurate: the differing perceptions of accuracy in cultural-heritage videogames between creators, consumers and critics,” *Rethinking History: The Journal of Theory and Practice* 21, no. 3 (2017): 435.

5 A. K. Przybylski, C. S. Rigby and R. M. Ryan, “A motivational model of video game engagement,” *Review of General Psychology* 14 (2010): 162.

6 Przybylski, Rigby and Ryan, “A motivational model,” 154–166.

games do not so much represent the past as they simulate it.⁷ Chapman and McCall have both suggested that the structures of historical games provide players with considerable opportunities to exercise agency within simulated historical environments.⁸ In an earlier paper, Chapman also noted that because historical video games are “actively configured by their audiences” they open up additional layers of meaning and provide opportunities for individuals to exercise agency.⁹ By embedding narrative and ludic structures in the simulated past, gamers are encouraged not just to imagine themselves in history, but to act through history. Simulated game-pasts enable gamers to actively work through shifting historical scenarios rather than passively consuming them, as was noted explicitly by a number of our respondents, including the following: “your actions have an actual, clear impact on the world around you based on which decisions you make, making you feel as though you can play how you want and not how the game tells you to play.” The establishment of a sense of authenticity, by situating gameplay within realistic historical contexts and/or placing gamers in accurate representations of past places, is a further means of cultivating a sense of player agency in historical games.¹⁰

Some respondents to our survey certainly described themselves as exercising a strong sense of agency when playing historical games. They expressed a deep engagement with and ownership of the character (or dynasty, kingdom, country, empire, or other kind of polity) with which they were playing, with one stating, “Set in medieval Europe and parts of Asia you take the role of a medieval noble, have to manage your dynasty and Kingdom.” There was sometimes a sense that the player progresses through history with their chosen polity, augmented by the “reality” of some of the events that are encountered: “It’s a game of advancing your country of choice into an empire.” On some occasions this was articulated in quite personalized language; one said, “You go back in time and play as one of your ancestors and live life as they did,” indicating quite a deep level of engagement. Engaging directly in authentic historical processes, such as “advancing your country” by engaging with “real events”; living life “as they did” by

7 W. Uricchio, “Simulation, history, and computer games,” in *Handbook of Computer Game Studies*, ed. J. Raessens and J. H. Goldstein (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2005), 327–338.

8 A. Chapman, *Digital Games as History: How Videogames Represent the Past and Offer Access to Historical Practice* (London: Routledge, 2016); J. McCall, “Teaching History With Digital Historical Games: An Introduction to the Field and Best Practices,” *Simulation & Gaming* 47, no. 4 (2016): 517–542.

9 A. Chapman, “Privileging form over content: Analysing historical videogames,” *Journal of Digital Humanities* 1, no. 2 (2012), accessed February 2, 2022, <http://journalofdigitalhumanities.org/1-2/privileging-form-over-content-by-adam-chapman/>.

10 Stirling and Wood, “Actual history doesn’t take place.”

playing as a historical character was thus viewed as enabling players to exercise agency in quite an individualized manner, positioning themselves as historical actors within the gameplay environment.

In our fiction, we also wanted to acknowledge the importance of “modding” for some gamers by incorporating the option for some students to design elements of the game for others. One participant suggested: “It’s very moddable and I am developing a mod for it to make the game more accurate, which other people have downloaded and play with too.”

It was clear to us from the survey results that there was no single reason why a student might choose to take a module on historical gaming. The personal experience of gameplay, whether carried out solo, in collaboration or in competition with others, was pivotal, as was the sense that such gameplay was potentially individualized (or even individualizable). This led us to consider what the actual module experience might be like and how that might relate to the experience of playing historical games.

Experience

We wanted to provide a sense of how respondents’ reflections on the process of playing digital games might relate to the student experience of taking our fictional module. Vital factors in generating a positive gaming experience included aesthetics, opportunities for social interaction, the ability to exercise choice, and the challenge of gameplay. We explore each of these features in turn in the next section.

Many of our respondents mentioned the aesthetic quality of games as being particularly important to their experience of gameplay. One suggested, “visual effects are stunning, plus there is presence of medieval history and mythical content all in one game,” and another that “all of this in glorious graphics! It’s perfect for any military history buff.” The high aesthetic quality of games is something many of the participants in our survey mentioned. It was one of the factors that reportedly encouraged repeat playing. High-end graphics that offered accurate reconstructions of historical sites were viewed as encouraging gamers to immerse themselves in gameplay, in some cases helping to cultivate a deeper sense of engagement and ownership.¹¹ Music and other elements that added to the atmosphere also potentially heightened player engagement. It has been argued that the

11 Stirling and Wood, “Actual history doesn’t take place.”

creation of such atmospheric gaming environments opens up new ways of crafting and participating in the past.¹²

Although we emphasized the individual motivations for playing historical games in the last section, our survey revealed that social factors were also important for some gamers, a fact that we were keen to acknowledge in our fiction. The collaborative potential was emphasized by one respondent in particular: “Gaming has a somewhat incorrect reputation as being somehow antisocial. It is a highly social activity in which one can make friends and bond over mutual interests and activities. The co-operation element generates many hours of gameplay for me.” Our fictional student so enjoyed the ability to work with others that they carried on into – even through – the night.

McCall has emphasized the role of choice in differentiating historical video games from other media.¹³ Gameplay can replicate (in an approximate sense) some of the decisions that historical actors made which affected their lives and those of others, and this can be a powerful learning tool.¹⁴ Some respondents to our survey demonstrated a sophisticated awareness of the potential of historical videogames to enable them to engage in counterfactual play.¹⁵ For example, one respondent to the question about why they liked their favourite historical game stated that it: “placed the player in multiple different societies and cultures, leading the story and characters to consider their impact on the people they met.” The process of gameplay in “authentic” historical contexts potentially enabled some gamers to exercise agency in shaping the course of in-game history: “It is set in Ancient Rome and contains a lot of real historical characters and events from the past, even if your actions may cause events to play out differently to how they actually occurred.” For another respondent it was the chance to affect the course of history that was particularly attractive: “Although not very accurate, it is based on the past. I like how it gives a great opportunity to re-shape actual history.” We were therefore keen to include a significant element of choice in our fictional module and wanted the student to reflect on what they had learnt by engaging in such simulated processes of historical choice-making (and re-making).

Students who responded to our survey repeatedly stressed their passion for playing challenging games. Difficulty was viewed positively in general terms with one respondent describing their favorite game as “difficult but interesting,

12 Copplestone, “But that’s not accurate.”

13 McCall, “Teaching History With Digital Historical Games”; J. McCall, *Gaming History: Using Video Games to Teach Secondary History* (London: Routledge, 2011).

14 Chapman, *Digital Games as History*; Copplestone, “But that’s not accurate.”

15 Stirling and Wood, “Actual history doesn’t take place.”

uses real events and people in history, casual game play is very interesting and there are always side quests to do during the game.” The challenging nature of some games means that gamers may have to work through scenarios repeatedly in order to figure out effective gameplay strategies. Relatedly, as noted above, the inbuilt re-playability of historical games enables players to make different decisions and thus to explore a range of potential outcomes of different historical scenarios. This provides them with an opportunity to explore and learn about the nature of historical contingency.¹⁶

Learning

It was clear that some student gamers learnt a lot about history by playing games set in the past. As we have seen, this extends beyond learning information about history to engaging in processes of historical – or quasi-historical – thinking. For example, the challenges that historical games present in terms of limitations on resources and actions and the presence of obstacles and antagonists means that they “can illustrate the systemic context of people in the past, the complicated physical and even ideological milieus in which agents in the past found themselves.”¹⁷

An important factor in deepening engagement with historical games is the extent to which they confirm respondents’ pre-existing historical knowledge, as has been acknowledged by Chapman, who notes how gamers’ ability to exercise agency is related to their knowledge of the past and broader discourses about history. For him, historical video games evoke “a player’s historical understanding, invoke the larger historical discourse and [provide] a challenging space for the players to exercise their (narrative) agency.”¹⁸

One of the respondents to the question “Why do you consider this game historical?” made a direct connection between prior historical knowledge and the design of the game, suggesting that once gameplay had commenced within an historical environment, gamers were able to “use familiar frameworks of history and mechanics built into the game to understand how historical figures, institutions and kingdoms interacted.” Presumably prior knowledge was judged to give

¹⁶ McCall, “Teaching History With Digital Historical Games,” 525.

¹⁷ McCall, “Teaching History With Digital Historical Games,” 524.

¹⁸ Chapman, *Digital Games as History*, 101. On gameplay narratives and agency more generally, see S. Domsch, *Storyplaying: Agency and narrative in video games* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 2013).

an advantage during gameplay within an historical scenario, a finding that aligns very well with Chapman's theories about the interrelationship between pre-existing historical knowledge and deepened engagement with games about the past.¹⁹

In order to understand students' roles as active agents in learning about the past through virtual play, we asked respondents to tell us what they did as a result of playing games. The results are presented in the following table (Table 2.1).

Table 2.1: From your experience of playing that game, did you? (n = 213).

Action	Frequency
Learn something	154
Try to find out more	148
Play another game	124
Talk to someone	93
Change the way you play the game	85
Visit a forum	47
Visit a place	43
Other	10

The most popular responses (try to find out more; learn something) both suggest that gamers thought that gameplay was connected to learning. This may be linked to the fact that some historical games encourage players to find out more about the past for themselves. For example, respondents reference the incorporation of encyclopaedias within games that allow players to find out about historic figures and key events. Responses to other questions indicate that respondents felt that historical games had piqued their interest in particular periods and introduced them to key historical actors. There was explicit recognition that games have the potential to engage people with history, including teaching them about specific places, ideas, and perspectives. Interesting too were responses that demonstrated the interplay between gameplay and the "real world," including participants who reported doing additional research into topics as a result of the game and even visiting places. Attempts to learn something were not restricted to the gameworld either, as was indicated by some of the free-text responses from those who selected "other":

¹⁹ Chapman, *Digital Games as History*.

- Used it to simulate the past so I can visualize it more;
- Got into historical reenactment;
- Found contextual knowledge that when researched, actually applied to school work I was working on and was correct;
- Actually got inspired to used real Norman weaponry;
- Start to make my own games;
- Watched Band of Brothers DVDs;
- Check the real history of it.

One of our follow-up questions asked about how gamers tried to find out more information, with the following options scoring highest: “online research” (149 responses), books (87), and Wikipedia (86). Free text responses mentioned TV documentaries, YouTube, discussions with friends and/or lecturers, and encyclopaedias, suggesting that respondents made use of a wide range of information sources when trying to find out more about the historical elements of games.

Respondents who selected “finding out more” and changing gameplay – and, potentially, talking to someone and/or visiting a forum – point towards the adoption of a strategic approach to the game. That a significant proportion (40%) of our respondents said that they changed the way that they played the game may be particularly significant. Working through different historical scenarios enables gamers to learn about the past, as discussed above. This was mentioned by one of the responses to a question about why a certain game was their favourite: “1. It has taught me about many nations and entities throughout history; 2. Although being alternate, does reflect perspectives of certain nations; 3. Alternate history.” Re-playability is a fundamental feature of video gaming and the strategic decision to change one’s approach to playing a game is not unusual, indicating that a baseline level of learning through reflection often takes place. However, as we have already noted, certain kinds of historical video games are particularly well-suited to engaging players in strategic thinking. Historical strategy games provide players with opportunities to engage in counterfactual play and to learn about the variability of historical contingency. One respondent reflected in a broader sense on what repeated gameplay can teach gamers: “It teaches you all about the grind. If you want something, go earn it.”

Methodology

Video games are digital places of cultural meaning making²⁰ and those that are set in the past combine past and present in their storyworlds.²¹ Historical video games (and to a lesser extent other genres, such as fantasy) implicitly – and sometimes explicitly – position themselves within historical and historiographical debates. Claims about games’ historical “accuracy” and “authenticity” often figure prominently in marketing materials for historical video games. Video game designers engage in processes of research and occasionally employ historical consultants when developing games and, in the process, make explicit – and implicit – decisions about how to present history.²² As a result, games can direct gamers towards very specific interpretations and understandings of the past and, particularly in the case of strategy games, encourage the reproduction and/or disruption of colonialist and hegemonic ideologies.²³ However, such pathways are often restricted and can reinforce established interpretations, a tendency that is often obscured by the fact that scenarios in (historical) games necessarily incorporate a degree of choice into the player experience, potentially creating something of an illusion of agency.²⁴ Copplestone suggests that “the move towards a less stratified and authoritative history has opened up new ways to think about and engage with the past, whilst refocusing attention on the role of the historian, or indeed the game developer in creating these accounts.”²⁵ Drawing on user-centered approaches to the study of video games, our study was explicitly designed to let gamers tell us about their perceptions of the impact of playing historical video games on their understanding of history. We were particularly interested in probing one of the central paradoxes of historical gaming: that gamers are tightly constrained in their ability to experience

20 K. Schut, “Strategic simulations and our past: the bias of computer games in the presentation of history,” *Games and Culture* 2, no. 3 (2007): 213–235.

21 D. Kirby, “The future is now: Diegetic prototypes and the role of popular films in generating real-world technological development,” *Social Studies of Science* 40, no. 1 (2009): 41–70.

22 D. N. Dow, “Historical Veneers: Anachronism, Simulation, and Art History in *Assassin’s Creed II*,” in *Playing with the Past: Digital Games and the Simulation of History*, ed. A. B. R. Elliott and M. W. Kappell (London: Bloomsbury, 2013), 215–231.

23 H. J. Brown, “The Consolation of Paranoia: Conspiracy, Epistemology, and the Templars in *Assassin’s Creed*, *Deus Ex*, and *Dragon Age*,” in *Digital Gaming Re-imagines the Middle Ages*, ed. D. T. Kline (London: Routledge, 2013), 217–240; A. Chapman, A. Foka and J. Westin, “Introduction: what is historical game studies?,” *Rethinking History: The Journal of Theory and Practice* 21, no. 3 (2017): 358–371.

24 McCall, “Teaching History With Digital Historical Games.”

25 Copplestone, “But that’s not accurate,” 419.

the past due to the games' ludic, narrative, and formal structures but at the same time the gameplay experience can provide them with opportunities for sophisticated ways of engaging with history.

Design Fiction and Speculative Design

In creating the speculative design fiction with which this chapter began, we used narrative approaches to data analysis underpinned by our wish to create a design fiction prototype to help us to imagine alternative futures for (history) education. A design fiction, as described by science fiction author Bruce Sterling,²⁶ allows us to suspend disbelief about change while at the same time opening up space for discussion²⁷ by using prototypes within a “storyworld.”²⁸ We used the speculative nature of the future-focused design fiction method to enable us to review our data in a way that is generative and exploratory. We used the module as a kind of “prototype” that enabled us to play with possible futures and to discuss alternative ways by which we might construct learning and teaching experiences within history education that are immersive, engaging, and draw on students' own experiences and perspectives.

Atkinson and Delamont propose that we should treat narratives as performance acts because they are forms of social action.²⁹ We were keen to make sure that our fiction was “loyal” to the data: it was written using 80% participant voices and 20% our narrative voice to give an insight into the range of different points of view articulated by respondents to our survey.³⁰ We based the fiction on an analysis of the data that drew on themes which we identified and refined after reviewing the dataset on several occasions.³¹ We then worked separately to code the overall dataset and then came together to review and cross

26 T. Bosch, “Sci-Fi Writer Bruce Sterling Explains the Intriguing New Concept of Design Fiction,” *Slate*, March 2, 2012, accessed February 2, 2022, <https://slate.com/technology/2012/03/bruce-sterling-on-design-fictions.html>.

27 A. Dunne and F. Raby, *Speculative everything: design, fiction, and social dreaming* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2013).

28 Kirby, “The future is now.”

29 P. Atkinson and S. Delamont, “Analytical Perspectives,” in *Collecting and interpreting qualitative materials*, 3rd edition, ed. N. K. Denzin and Y. S. Lincoln (London: Sage, 2005), 821–840.

30 C. Bold, *Using narrative in research* (London: Sage, 2011).

31 D. J. Clandinin and F. M. Connelly, *Experience and Story in Qualitative Research* (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2000).

check codes and emerging themes. We then extracted representative quotes from the participants' responses to the questionnaire to help us to exemplify the key themes and codes.

Conclusions

This chapter adds further “much-needed” data to facilitate our understanding of patterns of user experience and perception.³² We analyzed students' roles as active agents in learning about history through virtual play rather than as passive consumers of digital products that are set in the past. It complements an increasing amount of recent work that has sought to move beyond approaches focusing on how games represent the past by presenting gamers with fixed historical frameworks and instead to consider the various means by which historical games also construct individual and collective knowledge about the past.³³ For instance, McCall suggested that video games can play an important role in teaching high school students not just about historical knowledge, but also about historical processes.³⁴ The fiction sought to articulate not just what students thought they had learnt about history through playing “historical” video games in their free time, but also how they thought that they had learnt in a description of a learning context. Respondents to our survey – an admittedly self-selecting group of video gaming enthusiasts – almost without exception expressed positive opinions about video gaming, as noted above. We focused on three areas that had emerged in our survey. First, we were interested in why students were motivated to engage with historical video gameplay and how that might relate to choices that they make about learning. Second, we wanted to address the issue of the experience of historical videogaming and focused on how immersion seems to have been a powerful driver for engagement. Finally, we explored what students learn through historical videogaming. Our module prototype was a way of imagining how gaming could help to inform immersive teaching and learning experiences in history.

³² Chapman, Foka, and Westin, “Introduction.”

³³ Chapman, Foka, and Westin, “Introduction”; Copplestone, “But that’s not accurate.”

³⁴ McCall, *Gaming History*.

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